

**A Research Proposal using Hermeneutical Phenomenological Methodology: A Study of the
Lived Experiences of Supervisees Who Perceive Their Supervisors to Have a Strong God
Attachment**

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Author Note

I have no known conflicts of interest to disclose.

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Abstract

This research proposal aims to initiate a hermeneutic-phenomenological study, grounded in van Manen's method, to explore and describe the meaning of the experience of newly licensed counselors' attunement with their supervisors, whom they perceive as securely attached to God. The proposal provides prior research on the supervisory relationship, God attachment, attunement, and the development of effective counselors as separate factors relating to counselor development, as well as the author's personal experience with these phenomena as a conceptual framework. The proposal recommends a study that addresses the gap in a combination of these factors. Additionally, it presents the proposed design for the study, based on a qualitative methodology. The proposal includes the epistemological and philosophical framework for the study's design and procedures. The proposal suggests a design that is trustworthy and supported by prior research, yet remains open to suggestions for improvement. The rigor and trustworthiness of the design are articulated as a separate section, although they are considered throughout the proposal.

A Research Proposal using Hermeneutical Phenomenological Methodology: A Study of the Lived Experiences of Supervisees Who Perceive Their Supervisors to Have a Strong God Attachment

Supervision of newly licensed counselors is paramount in developing effective counselors (Ertl et al., 2023). Yet many counselors cannot articulate what factors of this relationship account for their development or lack of development. The purpose of this research study is to combine the previously understood factors of relationship and attunement with the previously unstudied factor of a supervisor's attachment to God to discover and communicate the new counselor's experience. As this is a hermeneutic study, the researcher's experience of the phenomenon and his experience of the research will be detailed as contributing factors to the findings, but not as a biased interpretation of the participant's experience.

In the first section, a brief review of the literature on each contributing factor will be examined. This section also includes the researcher's personal experience with the phenomenon as it relates to this study and the epistemological framework the study draws from. In the second section, the research question is stated, and a detailed description of the gap in the literature is provided. The third section outlines the proposed research method, including an explanation of the model. Lastly, a section is devoted to ensuring the study remains rigorous and trustworthy so it can be generalized to a broader population. There are no appendices included in this proposal.

Conceptual Framework

In proposing this study, I am relying on my personal experience of supervision throughout my professional development. I am also calling on my current epistemological frame to guide the design. These will be discussed in relation to the study. The design will also combine two existing theoretical perspectives, with four topics present in both concepts that have

not previously been unified. I will first provide a brief literature review of these four topics and then articulate my personal stances noted above.

Supervisory Relationship

The practice of developing as a counselor through a relationship with a supervisor is a hallmark of the vocation. Through courses, internships, and licensure, there is no question that one will do so under the direct supervision of an experienced therapist. There is much research on the benefits of this relationship, but is this relationship simply routine? Or does it have tangible effects relative to this study? According to Wilson et al. (2016), the supervisory relationship is not merely mechanical. The relationship can provide positive outcomes and support positive profession development, but it can also create adverse intrapersonal effects for the supervisee (Wilson et al., 2016). For this reason, Wilson et al. (2016) caution supervisees to stay aware of and intentionally shepherd all aspects of the relationship to mitigate adverse effects.

Similarly, the supervisory alliance, as a part of the supervision relationship, is reported to be an essential factor in the positive outcome of supervision (Ertl et al., 2023). This study touts relational-style developmental supervision, which they believe fosters greater cultural humility and effective communication within the supervisory relationship. One outcome of this type of collaborative supervision, according to Ertl et al. 2023, is that supervisee disclosures occur more frequently, enabling the development of competencies that are unknown to supervisors in other models.

Teichamn et al. (2023) reported that supervisees felt they could develop personal and professional competencies when they sensed their supervisor was holding them, helping them

sense them as a secure base. As we will see shortly, attachment theory, attunement, and supervisory relationship all intersect to propose theories for developing effective counselors.

God Attachment

There have been many studies connecting attachment theory to psychological well-being in adults (Njus & Scharmer, 2020). Among other things, Njus and Scharmer reported that secure attachment has many positive outcomes, including but not limited to positive affect and self-esteem. However, according to Njus and Scharmer, those studies did not distinguish between all factors relating to typical adult attachment frames and the specific effects of God attachment. Their research then focused on distinguishing between the two and found that a secure God attachment, independent of adult attachment style, can account for psychological well-being. As noted by Njus and Scharmer (2020), Kirkpatrick first drew on Answorth and Bowlby's ideas about attachment to argue that an individual's attachment to God (even if it is only a psychological attachment) could serve as a secure base from which to take risks in an unsafe world. Could this unsafe world be one's subjective experience of therapy from the counselor's perspective? Can we interpret a beginning counselor's experience of clients and the overall vocation to mean the same as others in the world? And how do emerging counselors experience their supervisors through this relationship?

Attunement

While the attunement of a supervisor to a supervisee has little research to reflect its experiences, the literature supports the need to be aware of the phenomenon. It is also, once again, interesting to note that most discussions of attunement are framed within the attachment theory framework. Attunement, as the ability of one person to accurately reflect the emotions of another, makes sense from the lens of attachment. It is no surprise that one such study reported

that, independent of client characteristics, therapists' attachment frame accounted for differences and variability in attunement with clients over time (Talia et al., 2020). And there is evidence that those in supervisory positions can operate in ways that significantly increase a supervisee's experience. Shaffer and Friedlander's (2017) research suggests that supervisees whose supervisors are more interpersonally relational report a higher degree of alliance or attunement. So, once again, we see that how a supervisor relates to a supervisee makes a difference in the experience they describe.

Effective Counselors

But the question remains whether supervisees describe this relationship as instrumental in developing them into effective counselors or as unimportant in this regard. As late as 2021, Tugendrajch et al. stated that their meta-analysis found that more research is needed to clarify which aspects of supervision produce effectiveness in counseling. Although the phenomenon may yet elude us, we know from the literature above that supervision is essential and is not going away. So, what do we know about supervision's role in developing effective counselors? One study (Landon et al., 2021) concluded that a supervisor's prime position to influence a counselor's professional development, combined with the selection of intentional supervisory models, can contribute to the counselor's positive growth and vocational self-concept.

Personal Experience

It has been my experience that all of these factors mattered to my personal and professional growth as a counselor and counselor educator. I had a supervisor who unashamedly and ethically communicated his secure attachment to God. As I understood it, this secure attachment didn't mean that he had no worries, doubts, or fears. It meant that he could invite God into his experience of life, whatever it brought. This shaped my understanding of an ethically

sound way to integrate faith and counseling, but it also shaped how I received his supervision. I did not receive him as an expert, but as a fellow traveler learning as we went along the path together. His attunement to me fluctuated, but I sensed that it was strongest when his fears and doubts were grounded in God as his secure base.

Positionality

On the topic of positionality, I have some thoughts that seem to matter to the study. One, I am a counselor educator who supervises emerging counselors in a graduate counseling program. Two, I hope to become a supervisor for associate counselors soon. Three, my supervisor for licensure was a person of deep and overt faith. I have fond memories and a positive experience from this time. Four, as a counselor educator, I would like to serve on my state licensure board at some point.

Interests

The topic of supervision and faith is important to me for several reasons. First, as noted above, I was supervised by a man who was overtly Christian in his interactions with me and in how he conceptualized clients. He was constantly using Scripture as a metaphor and as a guide to understanding human nature and psychopathology. Having had this experience, I reflect on the nurture I felt from his desire to draw near to God with me. I was often soothed from the stress of counseling by our conversations centered on Christ. I also reflect on the color his relationship with God offered on his insight into my countertransference and my clients' existential dilemmas. I have a wondering (one of his phrases) about how others might experience supervisors with a strong God attachment or with a faith that is in Fowler's Conjunctive stage of faith (1981).

Second, as a person who would like to include my own faith in supervisory relationships.

I am curious about when people find it helpful, encouraging, or additive, or when they find it unhelpful. I am wrestling with the qualitative language for this. It may be more about the themes that I will discover in this research. If the themes are centered on a similar experience to mine, I could generalize about the quality of faith as a valid offering. If the themes centered on less positive experiences, I could generalize the quality of faith as interfering with supervisory duties. The real truth is, I will not know until I ask, and I have a wondering.

Thirdly, I sense there are more supervisors out there like the one that I had. I want to encourage these supervisors to see their use of faith integration as a positive experience and to offer it more often without feeling ashamed.

Fourthly, as a counselor educator, I am curious about how to communicate a person's experience with a supervisor who uses faith integration. I can use my own experience, but communicating this phenomenon through data will be more accurate and exciting for students.

Assumptions

I have mentioned a few assumptions, but for the sake of clarity, let me make them explicit. One assumption is that only Christians will desire faith integration in supervision or a supervisor who is strong in their faith. Another similar assumption is that non-Christian supervisees will not want or appreciate this integration.

Biases

Relational epistemology is gaining ground in my heart. As such, it will be difficult to hear and read about people who have had a different experience from mine in supervision, but it is necessary to fully accept their subjective truth. My bias may cause me to defend against any view that does not see a supervisor with a strong attachment to God or a well-developed faith as positive.

I desire greatly to lead a generation of counselors into this type of counseling relationship. When they want to, I will be open to disclosing my own attachment to God in hopes that they can have the experience of a fellow traveler as I did. If they want an expert, they can read a book. But with God as a secure base, can I, along with other believers, lead emerging counselors on a journey to make sense of the fears and doubts associated with the counseling vocation?

Epistemological Frame

Despite the above bias, my epistemological frame for this proposal lies between postpositivist and critical realism. Both lend themselves to a hermeneutical-phenomenological study, as they hold to an objective truth that is difficult to see through our subjective experiences (Groff, 2000; Ravitch & Carl, 2021, p. 188). In other words, how we know what we know and what exactly we know is clouded by our own experiences. If we could see beyond our experiences, we would all come to the same conclusions about truth and human existence. Using a quantitative study or one that uses objective measures would not align with this epistemology. It is also my belief that a qualitative hermeneutic-phenomenological study will reveal aspects of the supervisory relationship related to a God attachment that objective measures would not account for. This frame will allow me to hear the perspective of the participants in the study and gain a clearer picture of their meaning of the experience. It is also possible with this frame to generalize the subjective reality of one participant to the subjective reality of all participants, bringing me closer to the objective reality of anyone who would have the same experience. This aligns with a hermeneutic-phenomenological model for the same reasons.

Research Question

For this study, I have one research question that will help guide the design. The question of “*What are supervisees’ lived experiences of attunement with supervisors who demonstrate strong God attachment?*” is derived from both experience and prior research. My personal experience, as articulated above, has provided a foundation for belief in the phenomenon. Having a supervisor with a strong God attachment, as I perceived it, showed me the potential meaning others could make of this experience. Suppose I, having experienced the relationship as attuned and sensing that my supervisor’s security in God helped him achieve that attunement. Why would others not experience a securely (God) attached supervisor in the same way?

Similarly, the existing literature and prior research on attunement, God attachment, and supervision leave room for such a phenomenon. The sampling of relevant research cited above does not account for these factors in combination. There is evidence that a secure adult attachment style allows for attunement from supervisor to supervisee. There is also evidence that people who report a secure attachment to God are healthier mentally. Finally, people who have encountered a supervisor who is relational and open have the lived experience of growth and development in supervision. The next logical step seems to be that my question, relating to the lived experience of supervisors with secure God attachments and their supervisees’ perceived attunement, should be investigated.

Research Methods

Research Design

For this study, I chose a hermeneutic-phenomenological method. As you will see, using van Manen’s method of listening to and articulating participants’ (or co-researchers, for the sake of a Critical Realism paradigm) lived experiences best suits this study. Van Manen is curious

about people's lived experience and is concerned with describing a phenomenon through their words (van Manen, 1997, p. 39). Though less objective than other models, van Manen is not abstract. In fact, the model has two concerns: the phenomenon's concreteness and its essential nature (van Manen, 1997, pp. 39-40). Therefore, the model seeks to describe the phenomenon through the co-researcher's lived experience, to the best of the researcher's ability and within the limits of the words available to describe it.

Though the model is less systematic than is sometimes helpful, this is the point. Drawing on the present experiences of in vivo co-researchers, one can describe the experience of the phenomenon as a co-creator of meaning. Once the experiences have been transcribed, the researchers can then set about forming themes, thematic statements, reflections, and interpret them into meaning statements (van Manen, 1997, pp. 86-109). These meaning statements are the best language to communicate another person's world. I will use this model to see the world through the eyes of my co-researchers and seek to describe what they see.

Research Relationships

At this point in the study, I do not foresee any specific relational concerns. However, hermeneutic research is not a typical form of bracketing for the researcher to eliminate bias. I must be aware that, as a hermeneutical researcher, interpreting not only the co-researcher's experience, but also my own, I will have areas of overlap and shared meaning with co-researchers. Hermeneutic phenomenology requires the researcher to remain reflective throughout the process (van Manen, 1997, p. 78). This means that it is not enough for me to interpret the study's themes once, but I will need to continue reflecting alone and with the co-researchers. Forming this type of relationship could cause me to over-associate with the co-researchers and inadvertently ask them to make my study easier by agreeing with me. However, as I intend to

choose co-researchers with whom I do not have a prior relationship and with whom I have not formed a bond, I foresee the ability to remain open to their subjective experiences. I will need to trust the process of a hermeneutic-phenomenological model and only articulate themes that come directly from the co-researchers' descriptions.

Setting and Participant Selection

I have chosen to include participants (or co-researchers, for the purpose of a Critical Realism paradigm) who are currently licensed associate counselors, supervised by licensed professional counselors in the State of Arkansas. I will interview these co-researchers via Microsoft Teams. There are three reasons I have chosen this setting and these participants. First, Teams automatically transcribes the interview in vivo. This means that I will capture all of the conversation while remaining present with the co-researcher, allowing me to listen well and formulate follow-up questions with a high confidence that I will gather the data needed for the study. Second, licensed associate counselors in the State of Arkansas are individuals that I have easy and wide access to. This will allow me to choose the appropriate number of co-researchers who provide enough data to discover and communicate themes. Third, this mirrors my experience in supervision with a securely attached supervisor. I was a licensed associate counselor in supervision with a licensed professional counselor in the state of Arkansas, and much of our relationship existed over a virtual platform.

Data Collection

Qualitative research is recursive, as it synthesizes data into increasingly succinct descriptions; iterative, as it loops through the recursive process, further developing precise language; and relational, as its subjects are human by design (Ravitch & Carl, 2021, p. 100). Therefore, the data collection in this study will be recursive, iterative, and relational.

Recursiveness will come through multiple interviews with the co-researchers. First, there will be an initial interview to assess whether the applicant meets the inclusion criteria: being a licensed associate counselor in the state of Arkansas who perceives their licensed professional counselor supervisor as securely attached to God. Second, there will be an interview gathering each co-researcher's lived experience in supervision with the supervisor. Thirdly, once analysis has begun, follow-up interviews will be conducted to assess the accuracy of thematic statements.

This member-checking process is indicative of the iterative nature of data collection. The iterative nature of the process will allow me to collect data using qualitative research methods, collecting data once to establish potential meaning, collecting data again to describe meaning, and finally collecting data as often as necessary to reach saturation in the research or the point in the study where no new data can be added.

At this point, it may be obvious why data collection must be relational. Asking co-researchers to set aside this much time in their already busy lives is no small favor to ask. If they do not understand the importance of the study and how the study will benefit them and others in the counseling profession, they will be hesitant to participate. It is crucial to communicate the "why" behind the study as we collect data. It is also essential that data collection be relational, as I am telling their story. I will need to create a safe environment for co-researchers to be open and vulnerable about their experience in supervision. This will also be important when we discuss the study's trustworthiness.

As the study will also hermeneutically include my experience of supervision and my experience of the experience. Some data collection will come from my research journal and memos. These documents will help optimize the interpretation and analysis of the study.

Data Analysis

The recursive nature of qualitative research does not equal an unstructured, ad hoc approach to methodology or writing (Ravitch & Carl, 2021, p. 330; van Manen, 1997, p. 86). The process described by van Manen in his seminal 1997 thesis, as forming thematic statements and “seeking meaning,” is the interpretive process at work. Others have called this process coding. Coding is simply the interpretation of the data collected through interviews and member checking. In fact, the idea of separating data collection from data analysis in a hermeneutic-phenomenological model seems a little obtuse. The process within the process is just as recursive and iterative as described above for collection alone. One cannot analyze/describe/interpret in one fell swoop. One must check back in to create increasingly accurate meaning from the co-researcher’s words and perspective. However, the structured aspect of data analysis is coding. Creating singular words that best describe the co-researcher’s meaning. Once these words have been systematized, they can be organized into themes. Themes are sentences that increasingly convey the co-researchers’ experience in ways that invite others to participate in their world.

Recursively coding, creating themes, checking in with co-researchers, interpreting, making meaning, and then back to coding is the method of analyzing data in this study. Van Manen asserts that we are not naturally “reflexively aware of our world” (1997, p. 182). Meaning that we need an intentional process to help us become aware of the meaning we are making of our experiences and, might I add, the meaning we are making of the meaning we make. All of this meaning-making is not enough if I am not able to articulate them into thick descriptions (Geertz, 1973). If the reader cannot fully understand the process and the “results” (i.e., the communication of the description of the participant’s experience), then the study is only half finished. Including “thick descriptions” of the design and process will contribute to the study’s increasingly succinct nature.

Trustworthiness

Thick descriptions are not part of data analysis alone; they also contribute to the trustworthiness, rigor, and validity of the study. As one factor in trustworthiness, thick descriptions provide generalizability, credibility, and validity to a study (Ravitch & Carl, 2021, p. 180). The above section on the study's design will serve as a framework for providing thick descriptions.

Coding is not only an element of research design; it also helps build rigor/trustworthiness when done well. Coding allows for transparency and collaboration in the research design. Member checking (checking back in with co-researchers for accuracy and completeness), if included in the coding process, is a strategy for remaining unbiased in the interpretation of the data (interview transcripts). Coding also follows a hermeneutic-phenomenological method in communicating only what the co-researchers have described. Interpretation can introduce bias if one does not follow the recursive and iterative process designed to hold the researcher accountable to the subjective truth of the co-researcher.

Bracketing is a term that has been used to describe the process of removing oneself from the act of interpretation in phenomenological methodology (LeVasseur, 2003). However, for a hermeneutic method, this paradigm does not make sense. LeVasseur (2003) suggests the idea of “persistent curiosity” when designing phenomenological studies where one wishes to include the experience of the researcher and wishes to produce rigorous findings. Remaining curious in this sense means the researcher remains open to the co-researcher's subjective experience without interposing too much of their own experience into the specific meaning they are making. The researcher's experience would contribute to the overall findings, but not change the meaning the co-researcher has communicated. The trustworthiness of this design rests on the previously

mentioned thick description of how and when one uses personal experience to interpret the data. This can only be accomplished by remaining true to the iterative nature of the qualitative framework.

Another way to stay true to this framework is through triangulation. Triangulation can take many forms, but for this design, it will be used in the coding process for data collection and analysis. Triangulation can be described as including many perspectives to ensure proper bracketing of researcher bias (Ravitch & Carl, 2021, p. 174). Asking outside collaborators (which in and of itself adds to trustworthiness) to code the transcripts separately from me will help regulate the use of my personal experience in supervision and validate any matching codes and themes.

As noted above, there are threats to the trustworthiness of a study like this. The most critical threat is personal bias introduced with such an open paradigm. A hermeneutic approach to phenomenology is both fitting and foreboding. An additional threat is generalizability. Can this study be generalized to broader populations than those being interviewed? The subjective nature of phenomenology would suggest the answer to that question is no. I must also consider confirmation bias. Am I choosing a group that is too narrow or too homogeneous for this study to be relevant?

These threats can all be mitigated if the qualitative research process is followed thoroughly. One researcher handling all of the data and all of the analysis is certainly not ideal. So, collaborating with coding experts will add validity to the analysis, and researcher bias can be held at bay. Including journals and memos as noted above will also reduce the threat. And, though the generalizability may suffer, the specific phenomenon is interesting enough to counselors who want to include their religion and spirituality in their identity and therapy that the

small population is not a concern for me. However, the nature of van Manen's theory is that objective reality (generalizability) is found through the subjectivity of individuals (1997). Again, there could be a way to broaden the study's population, and I'm open to suggestions, yet it seems essential to the study. If I can use LaVasseur (2003) to stay curiously aware of the conclusion I want to draw and steer myself (and ask others to hold me accountable to this in collaboration) to back to the experience of the co-researcher, I can avoid this bias.

Conclusion

Discovering the lived experience of attunement between emerging counselors and their supervisors, whom they perceive to be securely attached to God, is the purpose of this study. Previous studies have examined separate factors in the proposed research, but the author is unaware of any combination of these factors. The development of emerging counselors is essential not just to me or to our profession; it is crucial to the generation of clients currently developing psychopathologies as we speak. A good enough counselor creates good enough solutions and good enough mental health. If we are to continue increasing counselors' effectiveness and, therefore, the mental health of our population, we need to explore all the factors that contribute to this development. A supervisor's attachment to God is one of those factors that is theoretically pivotal in this greater landscape of counselor development. The research in this proposal will serve emerging counselors, supervisors, counselor educators, and clients who wish to include their religious and spiritual beliefs in their identity and in therapy, for current generations. It will also provide data for future research.

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